Character Types

In a similar way to Unicode properties, there is a class of escapes that will match with ASCII characters that have common properties, such as decimal digits, Latin alphabet characters, and spaces (both horizontal and vertical). The full list is given below.

Table 8-27. *PCRE character-type escape sequences*

\d	Decimal digit
\D	Not a decimal digit
\h	Horizontal whitespace
\H	Not horizontal whitespace
\s	Any whitespace
\S	Not any whitespace
\v	Vertical whitespace
\V	Not vertical whitespace
\w	Contiguous “word” (alphanumeric) characters
\W	Not a “word” (space, punctuation, control, etc.)

Assertions

Finally, we have the assertion escapes. These escapes differ from the rest in one important aspect: *consumption* of characters in the sample string. Now, you might be wondering what exactly the word “consumption” means in this context. It means simply that when a character in the sample string matches with part of the pattern (be it a one-for-one character match, meta-character, escape, or so on), the PRCE engine moves along to the next byte (or byte sequence) in the sample (and the next sequence in the expression). Assertions, however, do not do this; they instead define conditions to be met at specific parts of the sample without any change in the particular sample byte or bytes under consideration. This style of (sub)pattern matching is sometimes called *zero width*.